The Door in the Tree

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 1, Episode 10

The path around your own oak was narrower than the front path, but just as dry. Nib brought the explorer case. Lark carried the complete map on its backing. Above you, the treehouse roof peeped between the same old branches.

At the rear of the trunk, a crooked root reached over a curtain of vines. High above it, the great branch divided into a fork. Both matched the finished map.

Lark brushed the vines aside. A narrow seam ran through the bark beneath the root.

“It has been our tree all along,” Lark breathed in astonishment.

Nib looked up toward the comfortable front steps.

“We were living on the roof of the treasure,” Nib exclaimed.

Between the roots was a little brass flap. Three familiar letters shone on its front. Lark moved aside so you could see them.

“Try the instruction yourself,” Lark invited gently. “Read its whole word. If you want help, we'll join the sounds together.”

The word was tap. Nib followed your reading with a light tap on the flap. An ordinary catch clicked, and a shallow drawer slid forward. Another little word marked its front.

Lark set the matching folios on the dry ground. One held the picnic mat. The other held the joined paper.

“Which cover matches the drawer's word?” Lark asked softly. “Read map and mat right through to their different endings.”

Nib kept his paws beside the case while you considered the labels. He did not reach for the first one that looked familiar.

“I am waiting for the little sound at the end,” Nib explained proudly.

Lark took the completed map from its folio and slid its stiff backing into the shallow drawer. Above it was a small fitted lamp cup. She set the moonstone inside.

Amber light fell across the joined paper. The old hidden ink shone from the orchard line to the ridge, from the island to the meadow, and all the way back to the crooked root. Every piece belonged to the same path.

Behind the bark, a latch released.

Nib took the handle. The ground-level door swung inward on a broad hinge. Warm, dry air drifted out, carrying the smell of wood and old pages.

Inside stood shelves of illustrated explorer books. A great folding woodland atlas rested on a low table. On a little tray lay a golden acorn, small enough to fit your collection case.

Nib stared at the acorn. Then he looked very carefully around it.

“Is any of the treasure a picnic?” Nib asked with cautious optimism.

Lark laughed softly. She took the moonstone from its lamp cup; the latch stayed released. The stone returned to its traveling compartment. Nib set the acorn in the compartment beside it, where it rested snugly on the soft lining.

Beside the older books was one empty place. A plain cover lay below it.

“There is room for our story,” Lark murmured warmly.

You had nine completed journal pages. Lark added the tenth: the oak from behind, the opened door, and the small golden acorn. She left room beside the drawing for a word that had brought you here.

“Write tap on our last page,” Lark invited gently. “Use the brass flap if you want to check its letters. Three familiar sounds helped us open a very large secret.”

Nib brought the red ribbon from the meadow. Lark laid the ten pages in order and threaded the ribbon through their binding holes. The loose journal became one real book.

On the floor she spread three pictures: the torn map you had first found, the complete map, and the opened room.

“Which picture starts our adventure?” Lark asked softly. “Which belongs in the middle, and which shows how it ended? You can point, put them in order, or tell the story.”

Nib studied the picture of the torn map.

“It looked less promising on my nose,” Nib remembered thoughtfully.

Lark read a little of your new book aloud, leaving map and sat for you to join if you wished. Then she placed The Map Pieces beside the earlier explorers' books. It could be borrowed whenever you wanted to read it again.

The golden acorn stayed in your case. The completed map stayed complete. Your moonstone was ready to travel, and the library door remained open.

Nib settled his sandwich beside the case, carefully outside its treasure compartments.

“And a very small picnic,” Nib murmured contentedly.

Beyond the doorway, evening lay golden around the familiar oak. The atlas held paths for another day. Today, the lost map was whole, the Treasure Tree was found, and your first adventure had its ending.